

IBM Bob — Getting Started Guide

AI coding agent for real-world software engineering

IBM Bob is IBM's AI coding agent (an "AI SDLC partner") that works inside your own codebase: it can explain code, draw architecture diagrams, plan and implement features, review changes, run terminal commands, and connect to external tools - similar in spirit to other AI coding assistants, but built for real-world software engineering and legacy modernization work.

This guide is based on IBM's own docs (bob.ibm.com) and the official "**Bob Basics**" video series on the [IBM Bob YouTube channel](#).

1. What Bob Actually Does

- Answers questions about an existing codebase ("what does this do?")
- Draws architecture diagrams from real code
- Plans a new feature, then implements it
- Reviews your code changes and lets you accept/reject fixes with one click
- Runs terminal commands (via **Bob Shell**)
- Delegates research-heavy work to **subagents** and long tasks to **background tasks** so your main conversation doesn't get cluttered
- Connects to external tools/data via **MCP (Model Context Protocol)**

2. Installing Bob

- Go to bob.ibm.com/download and pick your OS.
- **macOS**: download the **.pkg**, run it, and follow the wizard. Check Apple menu → *About This Mac* to know whether you need the ARM (M1/M2/M3) or Intel build.
- **Windows**: download the **.exe**, run it, follow the wizard, keep the default install directory, click Finish.
- **Linux**: download the Debian (**.deb**) or Red Hat/Fedora (**.rpm**) package for your distro.
- Go to <https://bob.ibm.com/trial> and **create a free IBMid if you don't have one**
- Launch Bob and **sign in with your IBMid**
- After signing in you'll land on Bob's welcome page, where it may prompt you to install extensions/premium packages — skip these for general coding use.

3. Core Concepts You Need to Know

Concept	What it is
Modes	Agent mode = Bob edits/writes code. Ask mode = Q&A about the codebase, no edits. Plan mode = design/plan a feature before touching code.
Slash commands	Shortcuts like <code>/review</code> (code review) or <code>/erd</code> (entity-relationship diagram). Type <code>/</code> in the chat to see what's available.
Subagents	Bob spins up separate helper agents for heavy research (e.g., a planning task that burns 29,000 tokens exploring code) and returns only a <i>summary</i> to your main chat — so your context window stays clean. Bob asks for approval before spawning one.
Background tasks	Long-running jobs (e.g., writing release notes) that run while you keep chatting or reviewing something else.
Rules, Modes, Skills (customization)	You and your team can configure how Bob behaves - style, conventions, custom workflows. See bob.ibm.com/docs/ide/configuration .
Bob Shell	Lets you drive terminal/CLI tasks through Bob.
MCP integrations	Connects Bob to outside tools/data sources beyond your local codebase.

Golden rule from the docs: the more specific your request, the better the result. Practice on a real project, not a hypothetical one.

4. Where to Go Next

- **Docs:** bob.ibm.com/docs/ide
- **Videos:** youtube.com/@ibm-bob
- **Download/trial:** bob.ibm.com/download